DMC notes on 1984

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As with Doestevsky and "Notes from the Undeground" last week, a tremendous amount of work has been devoted to examining George Orwell's life, philosophy, and writing, and in particular to his book *1984*[1].

Here, I recall what I wrote in the preface about Tale 2 and then give some additional material.

1. Notes in Preface regarding Tale 2

Lenses: Disciplinary Surveillance (Foucault – Panopticon), Narrative Analysis (Bruner)

Our next story is *1984* by George Orwell, published in 1949, as society was struggling after WWII with how to face weapons of mass destruction: physical nuclear weapons, global technological warfare, and propaganda used for totalitarian control of minds.

We are all familiar with many references to how aspects of our current society are "Orwellian," with its police state[2] used to control outliers to the norms of society.

Many of us feel the constant stress of narratives[3] being imposed upon us, often without our conscious knowledge. Like the fish who does not have a concept for water, we may be unaware of how our thoughts are constrained by the hiding of evidence, which is made concrete in *1984* as the "memory hole". Or we may not notice how language can place limitations on our ability to think, as the language Newspeak is meant to do. Orwell's tale is so powerful because he has constructed a narrative, brilliantly written to focus on possibilities he sees with prophetic vision.

We will ask questions such as:

- *Mental control often attempts to flatten a person's inner life. How does the narrative use the "intentional states" (private thoughts) of the characters to defy the external world?*
- *In a "mentally controlled world," the system provides the "canonical script" (how one should think and act). How does the protagonist of our story create a "breach" in that script?*
- *In propaganda-heavy worlds, "truth" is whatever the state says. How does a "tale of defiance" use "narrative truth" to expose the lies of "systemic truth"?*

[1] Here is a web page of references and commentaries on 1984.

[2] On disciplinary surveillance, see:

- Discipline & Punish (1975), Panopticism by Michel Foucault, Vintage Books, 1995, pp. 195-228 translated from the French by Alan Sheridan, 1977.

  > Bentham's Panopticon, designed in the late eighteenth century, was a prison model in which inmates could be watched without knowing when they were under observation, encouraging them to internalize discipline. In Discipline and Punish, Foucault develops this model into a metaphor for modern power: surveillance across schools, factories, hospitals, prisons, and society as a whole leads people to regulate themselves.

[3] On narrative analysis, see

- "The Narrative Construction of Reality", Jerome Bruner, Critical Inquiry, Vol. 18, No. 1, Autumn 1991.
- "Bruner's Narrative Theory for DMC Course".

- *Why do we often use the "Dystopian" genre to talk about mental control? How does the genre itself help us understand what "defiance" looks like?*
- *What helps or hurts the ability of individual acts of defiance "accrue" into a movement?*

2. Additional Notes